have also been instructed to ensure that BRS offices in the districts are open and ready for Foundation Day. Party flags will be hoisted and various programmes organised to mark the day. More outreach events will follow as the polls near. Though KCR speaks of developing a national footprint for the BRS, winning the Telangana assembly polls by a comfortable majority is the top focus right now. A decisive victory is also central to his BRS expansion strategy in the contiguous states of Karnataka, Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh before next year's Lok Sabha poll.

The anti-incumbency after two consecutive terms is the biggest challenge for KCR (he assumed office on the formation of Telangana in June 2014). To offset it, the CM is focusing on delivering on some of his popular poll promises—the investment support Rythu Bandhu scheme for farmers, allotments under the 2BHK affordable housing scheme for the poor and a comprehensive investment support Dalit Bandhu scheme for the Scheduled Castes. There will also be a slew of umbrella schemes to provide social security, education and employment. Telangana ensures social security for its 4.4 million people. The state also spends Rs 42,000 crore annually on pensions, including for women and widows. BRS estimates suggest that at least 60,000 people in each constituency get the benefit of one scheme or the other.

Focusing on these beneficiaries, the government is to launch the Gruha Lakshmi housing and distribution of *podu* (shifting cultivation) lands and sheep in assembly constituencies in the coming months. Around 365,000 beneficiaries will be covered under the sheep distribution programme and nearly 4 lakh acres of podu lands will be distributed to 155,393 forest-dwellers. KCR has directed party leaders to ensure that the land deeds reach eligible beneficiaries without the involvement of middlemen. That apart, the state's industry-friendly policies have brought in some Rs 3.5 lakh crore in investment in the past eight years. Close to 20,000 industrial units are said to be operational in the state today, employing some three million people.


ANI

GUV PUTS BILLS ON ICE

Governor Isai Soundararajan has not cleared 10 'crucial bills', some sent to her in Sept. '22

- Azamabad Industrial Area (Termination and Regulation of Leases) Amendment Bill, 2022
- Telangana Municipal Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2022
- Telangana Public Employment (Regulation of Superannuation Age) (Amendment) Bill, 2022
- University of Forestry Telangana Bill, 2022
- Telangana Universities Common Recruitment Board Bill, 2022
- Telangana Motor Vehicles Taxation (Amendment) Bill, 2022
- Telangana State Private Universities (Establishment and Regulation) (Amendment) Bill, 2022
- Professor Jayashankar Telangana State Agricultural University (Amendment) Bill, 2023
- Telangana Panchayat Raj (Amendment) Bill, 2023
- Telangana Municipalities (Amendment) Bill, 2023

RIVAL CAMPAIGNS

A major concern for the BRS is the adversarial role state governor Tamilisai Soundararajan is playing by putting legislation passed by the state legislature on the backburner. The state moved the Supreme Court against the governor on March 2, pointing out that it is unconstitutional on her part to not clear 10 crucial bills pending since last year. Some of these bills have been in Raj Bhavan for over six months now with the governor reportedly refusing to clarify the reason for the inordinate delay. In the recent budget session, the legislature adopted five bills; the governor has given assent for the Money Appropriation Bill for 2023 and another for 2023-24 and kept the others on hold (see *Guv Puts Bills on Ice*).

The opposition BJP, meanwhile, is tweaking its strategy after its 11,123 *nukkad sabhas* (street corner meetings) failed to yield adequate response. It will now hold public meetings in all 119 assembly constituencies to prepare party workers. The saffron party is working on making 'Mission 90' (winning 90 assembly seats) a reality. That long-time BJP leaders and recent heavyweight entrants do not see eye-to-eye on putting up a concerted fight is, however, a dampener. Shah has tried to broker peace and has advised state BJP leaders to collate data on state government schemes, see where it has done badly and tweak a seat-by-seat strategy. KCR seems confident of his chances and has declared that he has no plans to seek an early election like he did in 2018. "All the surveys are in our favour. A majority of the MLAs will be retained. But corruption charges will not be tolerated," says KCR, for whom ticket distribution could become a daunting task.

The third player in the fray, the Congress, is trying hard to stay in the game. PCC president A. Revanth Reddy is on a statewide 'Yatra for Change', appealing to voters to give the Congress an opportunity and releasing constituency-wise chargesheets against BRS legislators. "After spending Rs 23 lakh crore through the budget and raising Rs 5 lakh crore as loans in nine years, KCR has nothing to show to Telangana except the loot of state resources," says Reddy. Unfazed by the attacks, KCR is taking it one step at a time. A triumphant state election could even open the doors to national ambitions in 2024. ■